Long Wharf Oars

Youth rowing and mentoring on New Haven Harbor

STATUS	501(c)(3) public charity, Connecticut
FOUNDED	2017
BASED IN	Long Wharf, New Haven (boathouse space shared with a marina)
SERVES	Teens ages 13–18 from the Hill, Fair Haven, and West Haven
ANNUAL BUDGET	About $185,000
STAFF	1 full-time director, 2 part-time coaches (seasonal)
VOLUNTEERS	About 25 (adult rowers, college athletes, parents)
REACH	60 teens per year; about 40 row all season

MISSION

Long Wharf Oars uses the discipline of rowing to help New Haven teens build strength, confidence, and lasting relationships with caring adults, on the water and off it.

OUR STORY

Two former college rowers started the club after noticing that almost no teens from the neighborhoods closest to the harbor had ever been on it. The first season was eight kids in a borrowed boat. Today the club owns four boats, runs spring and fall seasons, and has a small indoor program on rowing machines in winter.

WHO WE SERVE

Most rowers are students at New Haven and West Haven public high schools. About 70% qualify for free or reduced-price lunch. Many have never learned to swim when they join. No one pays to row; the club provides gear, snacks, and bus passes.

PROGRAMS

Learn to Row (spring and fall)
Six-week beginner season, four afternoons a week. Starts with swim testing at a partner pool, then water safety and basic technique. About 35 teens a year.

Competitive Squad
Returning rowers who train year-round and race at three or four regattas in New England. About 20 teens. Older rowers help coach the beginners.

Boathouse Hours (homework and mentoring)
Before practice, every rower spends 45 minutes on homework with a volunteer mentor. Mentors also help juniors and seniors with college and job applications.

HOW WE'RE FUNDED

Individual donors and a spring fundraiser regatta (45%), two family foundations (30%), a city youth services grant (15%), and equipment sponsorships from local businesses (10%).

WHAT WE TRACK TODAY

Attendance on a shared spreadsheet. Swim-test pass rates. Which seniors graduate and where they go next (collected informally by the director). Nothing on confidence, mentoring, or school outcomes beyond graduation.

WHAT WE'RE WRESTLING WITH

Funders keep asking how rowing changes school outcomes, and the club doesn't know how to show it. Retention drops sharply after the first season. The director wants to understand why some kids stay and others leave.

A MOMENT FROM OUR WORK

A sophomore who joined because a friend dared her failed the swim test twice. She came to every pool session for a month, passed, and two years later was coxing the varsity boat and teaching new rowers the same safety drills. (Details changed to protect privacy.)